

The Book of Enoch

1 Enoch

Angels, Judgment, and the Mysteries of Heaven — An Ancient Jewish Apocalyptic Text

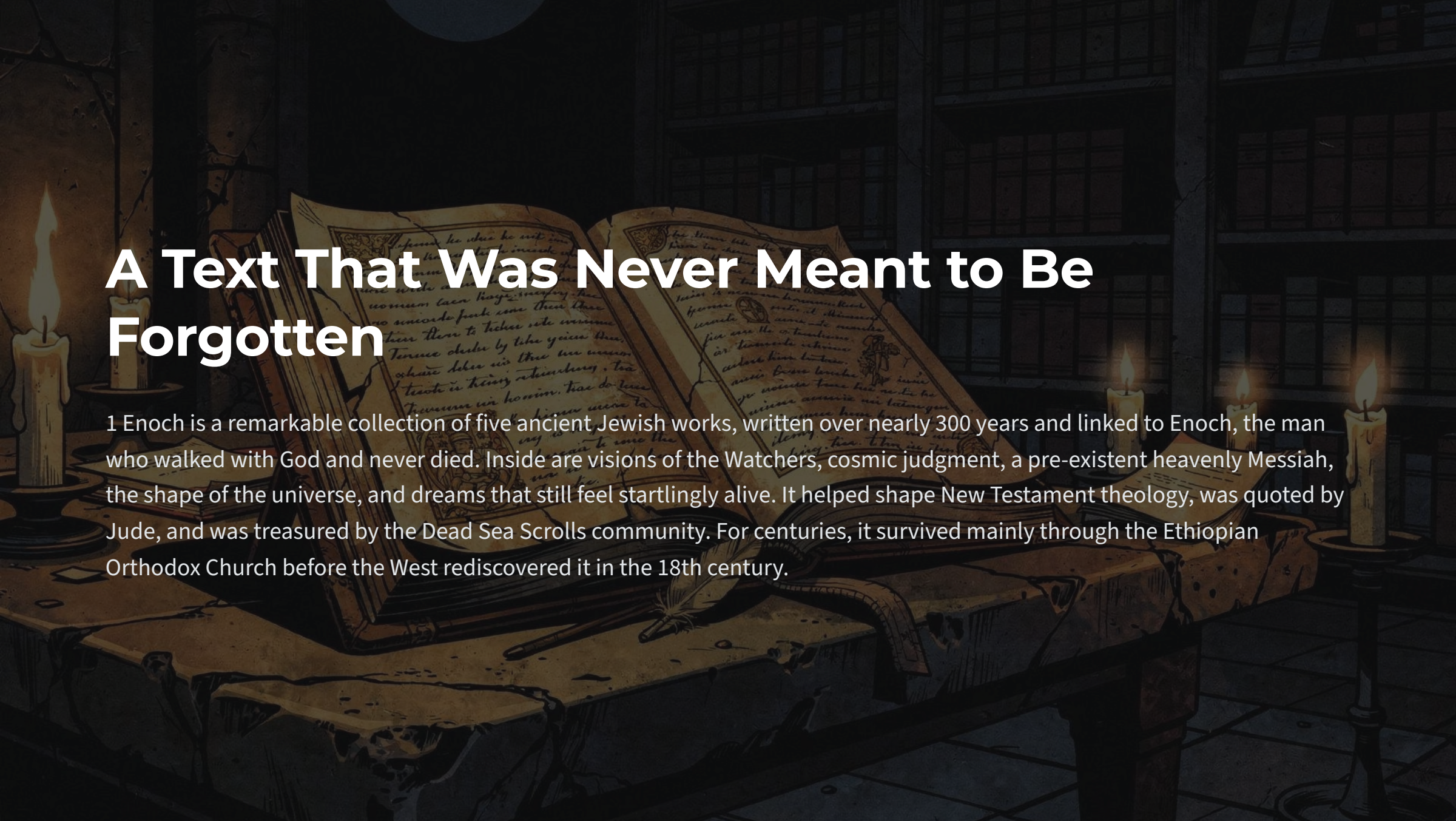
SECOND TEMPLE JUDAISM

APOCALYPTIC LITERATURE

PSEUDEPIGRAPHA

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A Text That Was Never Meant to Be Forgotten

1 Enoch is a remarkable collection of five ancient Jewish works, written over nearly 300 years and linked to Enoch, the man who walked with God and never died. Inside are visions of the Watchers, cosmic judgment, a pre-existent heavenly Messiah, the shape of the universe, and dreams that still feel startlingly alive. It helped shape New Testament theology, was quoted by Jude, and was treasured by the Dead Sea Scrolls community. For centuries, it survived mainly through the Ethiopian Orthodox Church before the West rediscovered it in the 18th century.



What Is the Book of Enoch?

The Book of Enoch, formally known as **1 Enoch**, is an apocalyptic collection of writings attributed to Enoch, the great-grandfather of Noah. In the Hebrew Bible, Enoch is described as a man who "walked with God, and he was not, for God took him" (Genesis 5:24). This tantalising verse made Enoch the only biblical figure besides Elijah said to have been taken directly to heaven without dying, and it became the seed from which an entire genre of Enochic literature grew.

Scholars universally agree that Enoch himself did not write the text. Rather, it is **pseudepigrapha**: a form of ancient literature in which a revered figure's name is adopted to lend authority to the work.

The text is not a single unified book but a **compilation of at least five originally separate documents** written by different authors across roughly three centuries, from approximately 300 BCE to the 1st century CE. What binds them together is a common apocalyptic literary style, a shared preoccupation with resisting the cultural corruption of Hellenism, and a fascination with Enoch as heaven's chosen witness and scribe.

At Its Core

1 Enoch is a work of **resistance literature**, designed to encourage faithful Jews suffering under Hellenistic cultural domination and political oppression during the Second Temple period (roughly 516 BCE to 70 CE).

Key Concerns

- The origin of evil and sin in the world
- Cosmic judgment and the vindication of the righteous
- A coming pre-existent heavenly Messiah
- Heavenly mysteries and the structure of the cosmos



Central Themes and New Testament Connections

The Origin of Evil

1 Enoch expands on Genesis 6:1-4, interpreting the "sons of God" as fallen angelic beings called the **Watchers**, explaining how sin, violence, and corruption entered the world.

Cosmic Judgment

Resounding visions of a coming Day of Judgment where sinners are destroyed and the righteous are vindicated form the backbone of the entire collection.

The Son of Man

A pre-existent heavenly figure called the "Son of Man," "the Chosen One," and the **Anointed One** who will come to judge the earth and establish God's kingdom.

Heavenly Mysteries

Enoch serves as a cosmic traveller guided by archangels through the heavens, the underworld, and the ends of the earth, revealing the structure of the cosmos and the fate of souls.

The book of Jude (vv. 14-15) directly quotes 1 Enoch 1:9. The title "Son of Man," which Jesus used for himself more than any other designation, is drawn in large part from the Enochic tradition alongside Daniel 7. The language of Revelation regarding judgment, angelic warfare, and the new creation echoes 1 Enoch closely.



How 1 Enoch Was Discovered

Preserved in Ethiopia

The Ethiopian Orthodox Church, one of the oldest Christian communities in the world, has considered 1 Enoch part of its biblical canon for over 2,000 years. The only complete surviving version exists in Ge'ez (Ethiopic), preserved through centuries of manuscript copying in Ethiopian monasteries.

1821: First English Translation

Oxford professor Richard Laurence published the first English translation, making 1 Enoch available to Western readers for the first time in over a millennium.

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1773: James Bruce

Scottish explorer James Bruce travelled to Ethiopia in search of the source of the Nile. He returned to Europe carrying three complete Ethiopic manuscripts of 1 Enoch, a landmark moment in 18th-century manuscript history.

3

4

1947-1956: Dead Sea Scrolls

A Bedouin shepherd discovered manuscripts in caves near Qumran. Cave 4 yielded fragments of at least 11 Aramaic manuscripts of 1 Enoch, dating to approximately 200-150 BCE, confirming the text's ancient origins.



The Dead Sea Scrolls and 1 Enoch

In the winter of 1946, a young Bedouin shepherd named Muhammad edh-Dhib was tending his goats near the cliffs of Qumran, on the northwest shore of the Dead Sea. Searching for a stray animal, he tossed a rock into a dark cave opening and heard, instead of a thud, the sharp crack of shattering pottery. Inside, he found tall clay jars sealed with lids, and inside those jars, ancient scrolls wrapped in linen. He had no idea what he had found. Neither did anyone else, at first. But word spread, more caves were searched, and between 1947 and 1956 the world slowly came to understand that one of the greatest manuscript discoveries in history had been made by accident, by a boy, a stray goat, and a thrown stone.

Among those 800 to 900 manuscripts pulled from the caves, one discovery stood out for scholars of ancient Jewish literature. Cave 4 at Qumran yielded fragments of at least 11 Aramaic manuscripts of 1 Enoch, covering roughly one-fifth of the complete text, and suddenly a book that had survived only in Ethiopian monasteries was confirmed as ancient, authoritative, and deeply embedded in the world of Second Temple Judaism.

- ✔ Today, fragments are housed primarily at the Shrine of the Book within the Israel Museum in Jerusalem, with a full digital library accessible online through the Dead Sea Scrolls Digital Library.

Why the Fragments Mattered

- Confirmed 1 Enoch was originally written in **Aramaic** (and possibly Hebrew), not Ethiopic, proving the Ethiopic text was a translation
- Demonstrated 1 Enoch was being actively copied and read **two centuries before Christ**, establishing its importance in Second Temple Judaism
- Showed the Ethiopic translation was a **remarkably faithful** transmission of the ancient original
- **No fragments** of the Book of Parables (Chapters 37-71) were found, suggesting that section was composed later than the rest





Section 1: The Book of the Watchers (Chapters 1-36)

Approximate Date of Composition: 3rd century BCE. The oldest, best-attested, and most widely known section of 1 Enoch, originally circulating as an independent text.

1	2	3
Chapters 1-11: The Fall of the Watchers 200 angelic beings, led by Shemihazah, swear an oath at Mount Hermon to corrupt humanity. A parallel leader, Azazel, teaches forbidden knowledge: weapons of war, sorcery, and divination. Their offspring, the Nephilim, dominate and enslave humanity. Four archangels are dispatched: Sariel warns Noah, Raphael binds Azazel, Gabriel destroys the Nephilim, and Michael binds the fallen Watchers in the abyss.	Chapters 12-16: Enoch as Intercessor The imprisoned Watchers plead with Enoch to intercede before God on their behalf. God's response is absolute refusal. A crucial theological detail emerges: the spirits of the Nephilim giants, after their physical bodies perish in the flood, continue to roam the earth as unclean spirits or demons, afflicting humanity until the final judgment. This is the understanding of the origin of demons presupposed by the Gospel narratives.	Chapters 17-36: Enoch's Cosmic Tour Enoch is guided by the seven archangels through the entire cosmos. He visits Tartarus where the Watchers are chained, the Mountain of the Dead (Sheol) with its four caves for different categories of the departed, the Mountain of God, the Valley of Hinnom (Gehenna), and finally Paradise itself, where the Tree of Life and the Tree of Wisdom still stand.



The Seven Archangels and Their Domains

Chapter 20 of the Book of the Watchers provides the most detailed pre-Christian listing of the archangels and their respective responsibilities over the cosmos and humanity.



Uriel

Uriel is the guardian of Tartarus, the subterranean prison where the fallen Watchers are chained until the final judgment. In 1 Enoch, he serves as Enoch's primary guide through the cosmic tour, explaining the movements of the sun, moon, and stars. He is also the angel sent to warn Noah of the coming flood.



Raphael

Raphael is appointed over the spirits of humanity and the healing of the earth. In 1 Enoch, God commands him to bind Azazel hand and foot and cast him into the darkness of the desert of Dudael, covering him with rough and jagged rocks until the day of judgment.



Reuel

Reuel is charged with taking vengeance on the world of the luminaries, executing divine judgment against fallen angelic beings who have corrupted the created order. His name means "friend of God," and he acts as an enforcer of cosmic justice.



Michael

Michael is the guardian and protector of Israel, and the most prominent of all the archangels in 1 Enoch. God commands him to bind the leader of the Watchers, Shemihazah, and his associates under the hills of the earth until the day of their judgment and condemnation.



Gabriel

Gabriel is set over Paradise, the serpents, and the cherubim. In 1 Enoch, he is commanded to destroy the Nephilim giants by inciting them to war against one another, so that they perish by mutual slaughter without God needing to intervene directly.



Remiel

Remiel is the shepherd of the souls of the departed, appointed over those who rise at the resurrection. His name means "mercy of God," and he is associated with hope and the vindication of the righteous dead.



Sariel

Sariel is appointed over the spirits of those who sin against the Holy Spirit, guarding the boundary between the holy and the profane. He is also identified in some traditions as the angel who instructed Enoch in the heavenly mysteries.



Section 2: The Book of Parables (Chapters 37-71)

Approximate Date of Composition: 1st century BCE to 1st century CE. The only section of 1 Enoch not found among the Dead Sea Scrolls, suggesting later composition. Widely considered the most theologically significant section for understanding the New Testament.

The Messianic Son of Man

The central figure is referred to by four titles used interchangeably:

- **The Son of Man**
- **The Chosen One**
- **The Anointed One** (Messiah)
- **The Righteous One**

This figure is portrayed as a pre-existent heavenly being who existed before the sun and stars were made, hidden by God until the time of his revelation, destined to sit on the throne of God's glory and act as God's agent of final judgment.

The Three Parables

1 The Coming Judgment (Ch. 38-44)

The Chosen One appears, sinners are driven from the presence of the righteous, and the cosmological secrets of lightning, thunder, and the storehouses of the winds are revealed.

2 The Son of Man Enthroned (Ch. 45-57)

The kings and mighty of the earth are brought before the enthroned Son of Man in terror. The righteous are raised from the dead into a transfigured world of light and eternal life.

3 Judgment of Angels and Rulers (Ch. 58-69)

The fallen Watchers are brought before the Son of Man and condemned alongside the earthly kings who made compacts with them.

i The Parables of Enoch represent the most developed pre-Christian interpretation of Daniel 7:13-14, showing that the concept of a "Son of Man" as a heavenly messianic judge was already well established in Jewish thought before Jesus. This is why scholars widely regard the Parables as essential background for understanding why Jesus chose this self-designation above all others.



Section 3: The Astronomical Book (Chapters 72-82)

Approximate Date of Composition: 3rd century BCE, possibly the oldest section of all 1 Enoch. Rather than apocalyptic narrative, it reads like an ancient scientific treatise on the workings of the universe, delivered by the archangel Uriel as Enoch's guide.

The 364-Day Solar Calendar

The Astronomical Book's central argument is that the correct calendar ordained by God is a **364-day solar calendar**: 52 weeks of exactly 7 days, divided into four seasons of 91 days each. This calendar was mathematically elegant: every year began on the same day of the week (Wednesday, following creation), meaning festivals always fell on the same weekday and the sacred calendar was perfectly predictable.

Uriel walks Enoch through the movements of the sun through twelve "gates" on the horizon, explaining how the days lengthen and shorten through the year and how the sun's path generates the seasons.

The Warning Against Calendar Corruption

"In the days of the sinners, the years will become shorter...and the moon will change its regular order and will not appear at its proper time."

This warning is a polemic against Hellenized Jews who, during Seleucid Greek domination of Judea from 175 BCE onward under Antiochus IV, adopted the Greek lunar calendar. For the author, abandoning the divinely ordained calendar was not merely a cultural accommodation: it was a cosmic sin that disrupted the order of creation. The same calendar controversy is attested in the Dead Sea Scrolls community at Qumran.

Storehouses of Weather

Wind, hail, frost, snow, mist, and dew all have their storehouses above the sky-dome

Flat Earth Cosmology

A solid sky-dome covers the flat earth, matching the standard ancient Near Eastern model also found in Genesis 1

Stars and Gates

The relationship of the stars to the gates of heaven and the measurement of days, months, and years

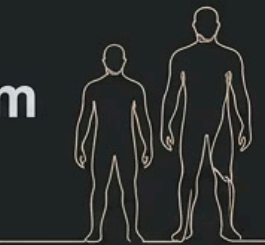
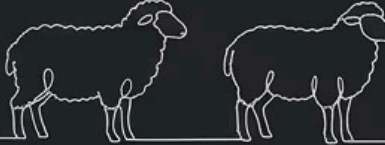


Section 4: The Book of Dream Visions (Chapters 83-90)

Approximate Date of Composition: 165-160 BCE, during the Maccabean revolt. Framed as Enoch recounting two prophetic dreams to his son Methuselah.

The Animal Apocalypse: A Complete Symbolic History

The second dream is one of the most elaborate passages in all of 1 Enoch: a complete retelling of the history of humanity from Adam to the Maccabean period using animal allegory.

White bulls: righteous humans (Adam, Seth, Noah)	Fallen stars: rebel Watcher angels 	Giants: Nephilim 	Black bulls: wicked humans 
Black bulls: wicked humans 	Black bulls: wicked humans 	Sheep: Israel 	Sheep: Isorans 
Wolves: Egyptians 	Dogs: Philistines 	Dogs: Babylonians 	Lions: Babylonians 
 Eagles: Persians	 Ravens: Seleucid Greeks	 Lord of the Sheep: God	 White bull among sheep: Messiah

The narrative proceeds through the antediluvian period, the patriarchs, the Exodus, the conquest and kingdom, the exile, and culminates in the Maccabean period where a great horn (widely identified as Judas Maccabaeus) leads the sheep in fighting back against the Seleucid ravens. At the climax, God descends, final judgment takes place, and a new Jerusalem is established where the sheep are transformed back into white bulls.



Section 5: The Epistle of Enoch (Chapters 91-108)

Approximate Date of Composition: Early 2nd century BCE. Structured as a written testament and letter from Enoch to future righteous generations, containing warnings, woes, blessings, and a final panoramic vision of history.

The Apocalypse of Weeks: History in Ten Symbolic Periods

Embedded within the Epistle is the Apocalypse of Weeks, considered the **oldest portion of all 1 Enoch**. It divides the entire sweep of history from creation to final judgment into ten "weeks."

Week	Era	Content
1	Enoch's birth	Enoch's own righteousness established
2	Noah	The flood; continued iniquity
3	Abraham	Chosen as the plant of righteous judgment
4	Moses	The giving of the Law at Sinai
5	Solomon	The Temple built in glory
6	Exile	The Temple burned; Israel scattered; Elijah taken to heaven
7	Current age	A perverse generation; but the righteous elect receive wisdom; the Watchers' deeds are exposed
8	Coming age	The sword of righteousness; sinners delivered to the righteous; a Temple built
9	Near end	All wickedness erased; the world written down for destruction
10	Final judgment	The great eternal judgment; the first heaven passes away; a new heaven appears

❏ The Apocalypse of Weeks places the author's own time period in Week 7, the darkest moment before dawn, giving his community the message that they are living in the penultimate act before God's final intervention.



Woes, Blessings, and the Conclusion

Woes Against Sinners (Chapters 94-100)

The Epistle contains some of the most vivid prophetic condemnations in all of ancient Jewish literature, a series of "woe oracles" against the wealthy, the oppressors, and those who built their prosperity on the suffering of the poor. These passages bear striking resemblance to James 5 and Luke 6 in the New Testament.

"Woe to you who build your houses through the toil of others: every stone, every brick of which is a sin."

"Woe to you, ye rich, for ye have trusted in your riches... In the days of your affluence, your sins were multiplied."

These woes are addressed specifically to wealthy Jewish collaborators and Hellenised priests who profited from the Seleucid system at the expense of faithful Jews.

Blessings for the Righteous (Chapters 100-105)

Balanced against the woes are extended blessings for the faithful, encouraging them to endure persecution with patience because God has recorded all their deeds in heavenly books.

Heavenly Books

All deeds, both righteous and wicked, are recorded and will be presented at judgment

Vindication

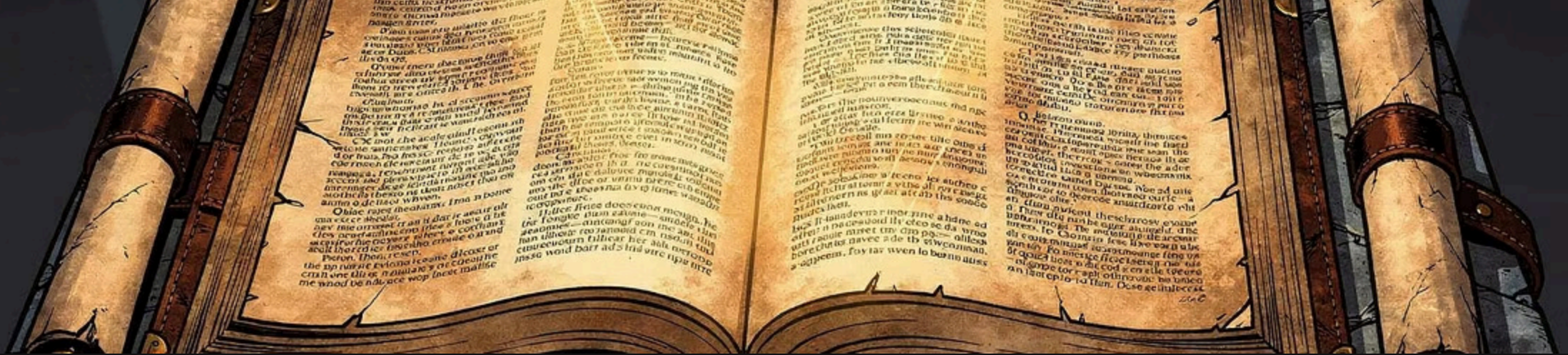
The righteous who have been oppressed, martyred, or denied justice will be vindicated

Resurrection

The righteous are raised to a transformed life of eternal fellowship with God

Cosmic Reversal

The present order, where the wicked prosper and the righteous suffer, will be completely overturned



Theological Significance and Legacy

1 Enoch represents a critical window into the theological world of Second Temple Judaism, the period between the latest Old Testament writings and the emergence of Christianity.



For Understanding the New Testament

The text fills in the conceptual background for many New Testament themes that would otherwise seem to appear from nowhere: the figure of the Son of Man, the imprisonment of fallen angels, the origin of demons as disembodied spirits of the Nephilim, the image of Gehenna as a place of eternal punishment, and the language of the tree of life in the new Jerusalem.



For Angelology and Demonology

1 Enoch provides the most developed pre-Christian account of the hierarchy of angels, the nature of fallen angelic beings, and the moral mechanics of the invisible world. Much of what later became standard Christian and Jewish teaching on angels and demons traces directly to traditions found in 1 Enoch.



For Jewish Resistance Literature

Read against the backdrop of Hellenistic cultural imperialism and the Maccabean crisis, 1 Enoch is a profoundly pastoral document: an encouragement to a community under pressure to hold fast to their identity and their God, confident that history is moving toward a final divine reckoning.



Canonical Status and Scholarly Importance

Canonical Today

1 Enoch is accepted as canonical Scripture only by:

- **The Ethiopian Orthodox Church**
- **The Eritrean Orthodox Church**

It is treated as important but non-canonical extra-biblical literature by most other Christian traditions and by mainstream Judaism.

Scholars across all traditions, however, regard it as **indispensable** for understanding the world in which both rabbinic Judaism and early Christianity emerged.

Why It Matters to Every Reader of the Bible

01

Background to the Gospels

The title "Son of Man" that Jesus used for himself more than any other designation is drawn in large part from the Enochic tradition.

Understanding 1 Enoch illuminates why this title carried such weight.

02

Origin of Demons

The Gospel narratives of demonic possession presuppose the Enochic understanding that demons are the disembodied spirits of the Nephilim, roaming the earth after the flood.

03

Jude's Direct Quotation

The New Testament book of Jude (vv. 14-15) directly quotes 1 Enoch 1:9, making 1 Enoch the only non-canonical text explicitly cited as prophecy in the New Testament.

04

Revelation's Imagery

The language of Revelation regarding judgment, angelic warfare, the tree of life, and the new creation echoes 1 Enoch so closely that the two texts must be read in dialogue with each other.



Summary: The Book of Enoch

1 Enoch is a pseudepigraphical collection of five originally independent Jewish texts, carried into being over nearly three centuries from 300 BCE to the first century CE. Though it bears the name of Enoch, the man who walked with God and never died, the work feels like a torch passed from hand to hand, united by apocalyptic fire, a refusal of Hellenistic corruption, and a vision of Enoch as heaven's chosen scribe.

Through every page, four great mysteries keep returning like firelight on the same old walls: the birth of evil in the fall of the Watchers, the certainty of cosmic judgment, the identity of a pre-existent heavenly Messiah called the Son of Man, and the unveiling of hidden knowledge about the cosmos. These threads did not merely linger in the background, they entered the New Testament itself. Jude quotes 1 Enoch 1:9, Jesus' use of the title Son of Man draws from Enochic tradition, and the imagery of Revelation echoes it closely.

For centuries, the Ethiopian Orthodox Church kept the text safe when the wider world had nearly forgotten it, until James Bruce carried it to Europe in 1773 and it first appeared in English in 1821. Then the Dead Sea Scrolls opened another door, confirming its ancient voice with eleven Aramaic manuscripts found at Qumran dating to two centuries before Christ. Today it is canonical only in the Ethiopian and Eritrean Orthodox Churches, but scholars across all traditions still turn to it as a key for understanding Second Temple Judaism and the rise of Christianity.

1 — **Book of the Watchers**

Ch. 1-36, 3rd century BCE: Fall of the Watchers, Enoch as intercessor, and a cosmic tour through Tartarus, Sheol, and Paradise.

2 — **Book of Parables**

Ch. 37-71, 1st century BCE to 1st century CE: The Son of Man enthroned, three parables of judgment, and Enoch's exaltation.

3 — **Astronomical Book**

Ch. 72-82, 3rd century BCE: The 364-day solar calendar, cosmology of the heavens, and a polemic against calendar corruption.

4 — **Book of Dream Visions**

Ch. 83-90, 165-160 BCE: The Animal Apocalypse, symbolic history from Adam to the Maccabean revolt.

5 — **Epistle of Enoch**

Ch. 91-108, early 2nd century BCE: Apocalypse of Weeks, woe oracles against sinners, and blessings for the righteous.

The Pentateuch of Enoch:

Five Visions of an Ancient Scribe



The Book of the Watchers (Chapters 1–36)

The Fall of the Angels

This earliest section details the rebellion of 200 angels (Watchers) who descended to Mount Hermon to mate with human women and teach forbidden arts.

The Origin of Evil

The union of angels and humans produced the Nephilim: violent giants whose spirits remained on earth as demons after their physical bodies perished in the flood.

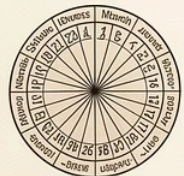
Imagery: The Falling Stars

Visualized as stars falling from the sky to pasture among cattle, representing the celestial beings descending to the human realm.

The Astronomical Book (Chapters 72–82)

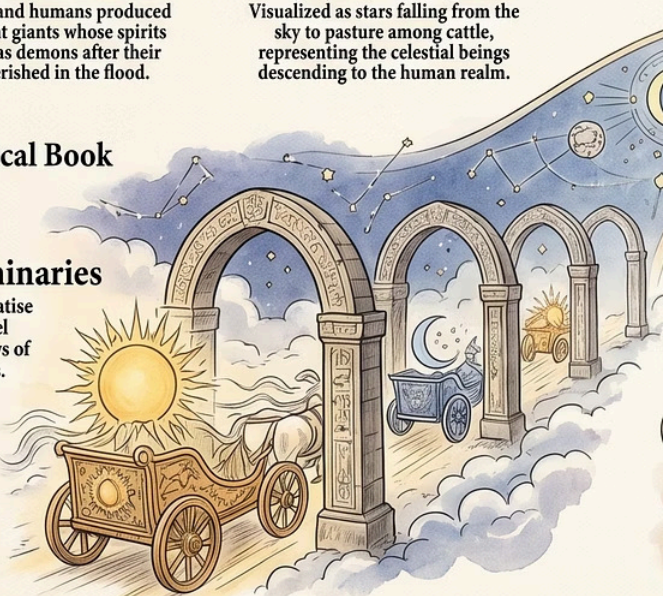
The Book of Heavenly Luminaries

An ancient scientific treatise revealed by the archangel Uriel concerning the laws of the sun, moon, and stars.



The 364-Day Solar Calendar

The author argues for a mathematically perfect solar year of 52 weeks; a calendar they believed was divinely ordained to prevent “cosmic sin” and calendar corruption.



Imagery: Portals of the Sun

Chariots driven by the wind carrying the sun and moon through twelve massive portals (gates) at the eastern and western horizons.

The Visionary Witness

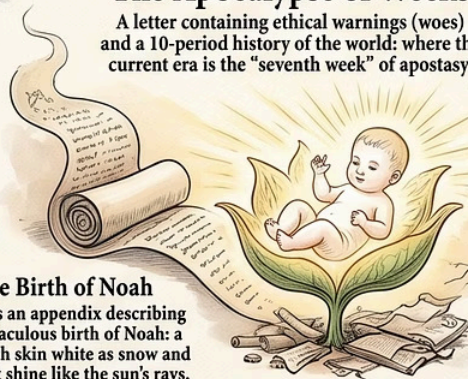
At the center is Enoch, the man who “walked with God,” depicted as a professional scribe holding a stylus and a long, unrolling scroll to record the secrets of the universe.



The Epistle of Enoch (Chapters 91–108)

The Apocalypse of Weeks

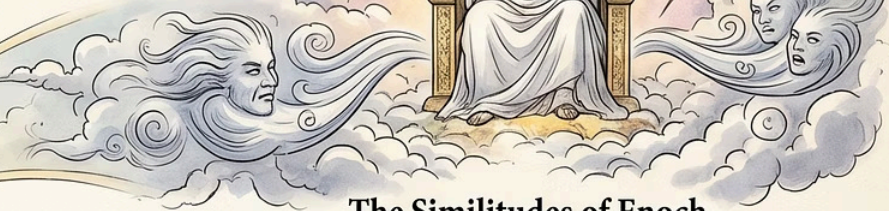
A letter containing ethical warnings (woes) and a 10-period history of the world: where the current era is the “seventh week” of apostasy.



The Birth of Noah

Includes an appendix describing the miraculous birth of Noah: a child with skin white as snow and eyes that shine like the sun’s rays.

The Book of Parables (Chapters 37–71)



The Similitudes of Enoch

A collection of three discourses focused on the final judgment of both wicked kings and fallen angels.

The Messianic Son of Man

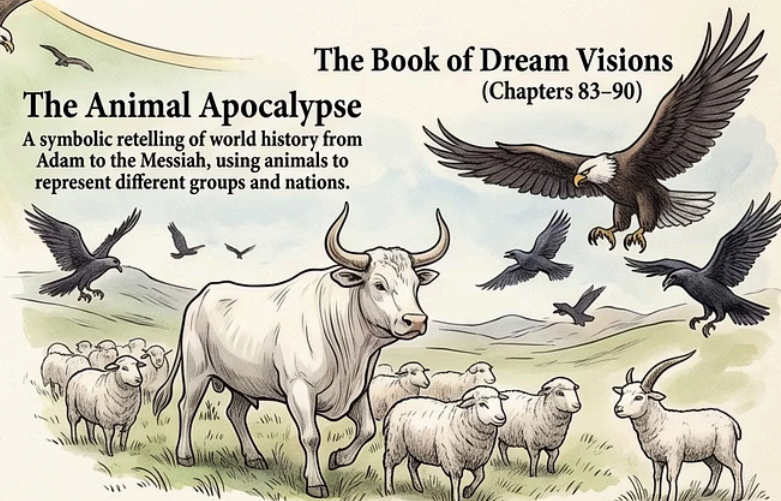
Introduces a pre-existent heavenly judge called the “Son of Man” or “The Elect One” who sits on a throne of glory to evaluate the deeds of humanity.

Imagery: The Throne of Glory

A majestic throne surrounded by “The Lord of Spirits” and innumerable archangels, with “hidden storerooms” of lightning and wind nearby.

The Animal Apocalypse

A symbolic retelling of world history from Adam to the Messiah, using animals to represent different groups and nations.



The Book of Dream Visions (Chapters 83–90)

Beasts and Birds of Prey

The righteous are depicted as white bulls or sheep; while enemies like the Babylonians and Greeks appear as lions, eagles, and ravens.

Imagery: The Great Horn

A lamb growing a great horn (often identified as Judas Maccabaeus) to lead the faithful sheep against the birds of prey during a time of war.

Imagery: The Plant of Truth

The righteous remnant described as a “plant of uprightness” that grows through the centuries of human history.